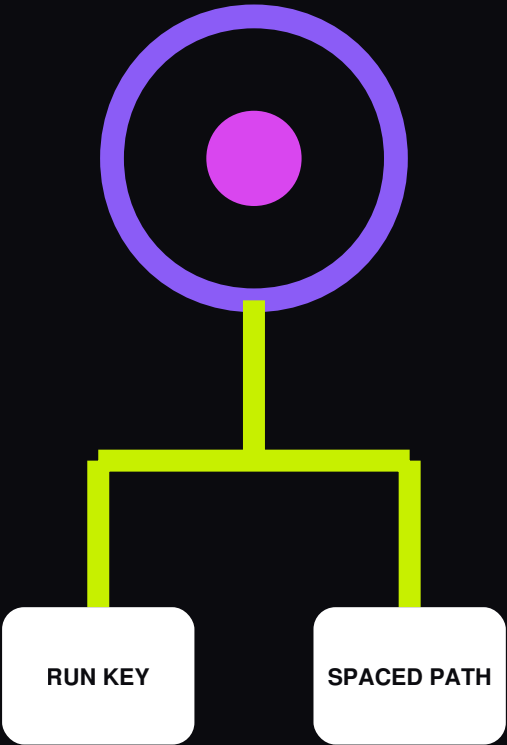


RUN-KEY TO SPACED WINDOWS DIRECTORY

Hunts for a Run-key value pointing to C:\Windows\SysWOW64, the actor-created lookalike directory most commonly observed for CHOSEN BRICK payload staging.

HUNTING QUERY

CONFIDENCE: MEDIUM



EVIDENCE BEFORE ALERTING

REPORT DATE	STATUS
16 September 2026	Untested implementation sketch
PRIMARY PLATFORM	OPERATIONAL VALUE
Microsoft Defender XDR	9.7 / 10



EXECUTIVE ASSESSMENT

Decision, confidence and evidence boundary.

ASSESSMENT

OPERATIONAL VALUE

9.7

Hunts for a Run-key value pointing to C:\Windows \SysWOW64, the actor-created lookalike directory most commonly observed for CHOSEN BRICK payload staging.

STATUS

Hunting query

Untested implementation sketch; Confidence Medium.

- 1primary table
- 0joins
- 0secondary rules
- 2validation gates

Evidence boundary

A match establishes the source-observed persistence artifact. It does not prove CHOSEN BRICK execution, Telegram C2, collection, exfiltration, or Iranian-state attribution.



BEHAVIOR AND EVIDENCE

Observed facts separated from analytical scope.

MECHANICS

Source-supported fact

- 1 The NCSC/FBI/AIVD advisory was published on 15 September 2026; activity is observed from at least 2025.
- 2 CHOSEN BRICK most often persists through HKCU\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Run.
- 3 The most commonly observed additional-payload location is C:\Windows \SysWOW64, with a literal space after Windows.

Detection hypothesis

If an attacker repeats this behavior, DeviceRegistryEvents should expose the same source-supported identity or content-access pattern. Distinction requires ownership, change, device, sign-in, and approved-automation context.

Unconfirmed elements

A match establishes the source-observed persistence artifact. It does not prove CHOSEN BRICK execution, Telegram C2, collection, exfiltration, or Iranian-state attribution.

Logic: Campaign-specific artifact + persistence behavior **ATT&CK:** T1547.001



TELEMETRY CONTRACT

Collection prerequisites and field reliability.

TELEMETRY

REQUIRED

Microsoft Defender for Endpoint coverage and DeviceRegistryEvents preserving RegistryKey and literal RegistryValueData.

OPTIONAL ENRICHMENT

DeviceFileEvents, DeviceProcessEvents, signer/hash, file prevalence, device/user criticality, Defender configuration changes, and network telemetry.

Fields	Reliability	Use
Timestamp, DeviceId, DeviceName, ReportId	Documented	Query or triage
RegistryKey, RegistryValueName, RegistryValueData	Documented	Query or triage
InitiatingProcessFileName, CommandLine, AccountName	Documented	Query or triage
C:\Windows\SysWOW64 literal path	Present in source	Query or triage
Coverage and retention	Environment-dependent	Query or triage

Excluded

No message body, phishing-page content, inferred success, actor attribution, or undocumented cross-SIEM mapping is used.



PRIMARY KQL

Direct source-supported conditions with investigable output.

HUNTING

STATUS

Hunting query — Untested implementation sketch

KQL — UNTESTED

```
DeviceRegistryEvents
| where RegistryKey endswith @"\Software\Microsoft\Windows\CurrentVersion\Run"
| where RegistryValueData contains @"C:\Windows \SysWOW64\"
| project Timestamp, DeviceId, DeviceName, ActionType,
    RegistryKey, RegistryValueName, RegistryValueData,
    InitiatingProcessFileName, InitiatingProcessCommandLine,
    InitiatingProcessAccountName, ReportId
| order by Timestamp desc
```

WINDOW	THRESHOLD	JOIN	KEY
None	None	None	DeviceId + ReportId



TRIAGE AND TUNING

Human validation before response.

WORKFLOW

1

Preserve

Retain registry key, value name/data, device, timestamp, initiating process/account, and ReportId.

2

Confirm

Verify the literal space, file existence, signer/hash, user, device owner, and approved change record.

3

Enrich

DeviceFileEvents, DeviceProcessEvents, signer/hash, file prevalence, device/user criticality, Defender configuration changes, and network telemetry.

4

Scope

Review adjacent process, file, Defender configuration, and network evidence without assuming C2 or theft.

Expected benign overlap

Authorized red-team or detection tests, lab simulations, and software that intentionally creates the spaced lookalike directory. Use only owner-backed, time-bounded exclusions.

Response boundary

A match establishes the source-observed persistence artifact. It does not prove CHOSEN BRICK execution, Telegram C2, collection, exfiltration, or Iranian-state attribution.



VALIDATION GATES

Controlled tests and cross-SIEM limits.

QUALITY CONTROL

Validation steps

- 1. Confirm DeviceRegistryEvents coverage on a Windows test endpoint.
- 2. Create an inert spaced directory and benign Run value in a lab, then remove both.
- 3. Verify literal-space preservation plus initiating process and account context.
- 4. Search 30 days and attribute every historical hit before alerting.

Decision criteria

Success: The controlled change produces one complete event and historical hits are absent or attributable.

Rejection: The value is normalized or benign overlap cannot be separated.

Failure: No test event, absent endpoint coverage, insufficient retention, or an indirect value that omits the path.

Platform	Decision	Missing evidence
Defender XDR	Hunting query	Literal path preservation and baseline
Splunk	No reliable implementation	Raw registry event, parser, sample
Chronicle	No reliable implementation	Parser and exact UDM mapping



CONCLUSION AND REFERENCES

Coverage statement and document control.

FINAL

CONCLUSION

Hunting query

Hunts for a Run-key value pointing to C:\Windows \SysWOW64, the actor-created lookalike directory most commonly observed for CHOSEN BRICK payload staging.

A match establishes the source-observed persistence artifact. It does not prove CHOSEN BRICK execution, Telegram C2, collection, exfiltration, or Iranian-state attribution.

MITRE ATT&CK

T1547.001

References

1. NCSC/FBI/AIVD — CHOSEN BRICK joint advisory — 15 Sep 2026
2. FBI IC3 — Technical advisory PDF, Version 1 — 15 Sep 2026
3. Microsoft — DeviceRegistryEvents schema — accessed 16 Sep 2026
4. MITRE ATT&CK — T1547.001 Registry Run Keys / Startup Folder

Document control

English dossier. No customer data. URLs are defanged in references.txt. HTML and rendering assets remain private.